Kashmir, HuM became even more enmeshed in the Taliban's war against the Northern Alliance and with al-Qaeda. Khalil was a founding member of bin Laden's International Islamic Front for Jihad Against the Jews and Crusaders. He was also one of the signatories to the 1998 fatwa issued by the International Islamic Front calling for attacks on Americans at home and abroad.[24] This affinity toward al-Qaeda carried over to Jaish-e-Mohammad after it split from HuM.[25] During its short lifespan before 9/11, JeM was very active in Afghanistan in addition to its activities in Indian-administered Kashmir. Because cadres moved back and forth among the Deobandi groups, this increased the personal connections among the groups themselves as well as between them and al-Qaeda.

Lashkar's cadres were never as portable as those from the Deobandi groups, meaning they did not move back and forth as frequently between different outfits, though some members did leave to join the Taliban. From an organizational leadership perspective, the group's leaders were less willing than al-Qaeda's to overlook doctrinal disputes. Several Lashkar members made clear to the author their disdain for adherents of Deobandi Islam and Zafar Iqbal, one of Lashkar's founders and the head of its education department, once referred to the Taliban as 'a group of misguided elements' and suggested his organization had 'higher ideal[s] than them.'[26] This does not mean that Lashkar had no relations with the Taliban, and its fighters did cooperate with those from the Deobandi groups on the ground in Indian-administered Kashmir. But these were ad hoc alliances. Outside of the Kashmir theater the sectarian divide between the Ahl-e-Hadith Lashkar and the Deobandis hindered close cooperation. Indeed Lashkar's cadres were training at the al-Badr camps when the Taliban originally handed them over to Harkat-ul-Ansar, but sectarian antagonism forced it to shift many of them elsewhere.[27] Further, Lashkar's strongest Afghan connections remained to Kunar and Nuristan provinces. Gulbuddin Hekmatyar's Hizb-e-Islami had driven Lashkar's former patron Jamil al-Rahman out of Kunar. In 1996 the Taliban defeated the Hizb-e-Islami and claimed dominion over Kunar province. However, the local Salafis did not recognize its right to rule and rejected the Deobandi Taliban on theological grounds. One scholar described Kunar as the place where 'the people resent the Qandahari ascendance [of the Taliban] almost as much as Uzbeks, Tajiks, and Shi'a Hazaras do.'[28] Many of the local Salafis in Kunar